

Quick Start Guide

Set up your renovation in 10 minutes — then spend 10 minutes a week staying in control of budget, contractors, payments and timeline.

Working budget (€) 121,500 of 135,000 total budget	Committed (€) 103,920 86% of working budget	Invoiced (€) 53,550 52% of committed	Paid (€) 46,390 Cash needed next 30 days: 25,820	Remaining to commit (€) 17,580 working budget – committed
Forecast final cost (€) 131,840 incl. risk: 137,640	Over / under budget (€) +10,340 ▲ over working budget	Contingency used 77% 	Project day Day 106 of 173 67 days to target move-in	Time elapsed 61%
Forecast move-in 01 Sep 2026 11 days after target	Open issues 5 1 high severity	Overdue items 11 of 33 alerts in total	Decisions waiting 4 see Selections & Orders	Orders due 3 1 already late
RENOVATION HEALTH				
● ACTION REQUIRED				
Budget	●	Forecast € 131,840 vs working budget € 121,500 — eating into contingency		
Timeline	●	1 late task(s) that other tasks depend on · forecast move-in 11 days after target		
Contractors & payments	●	1 overdue payment(s) · 1 paying-ahead warning(s) · 2 payment(s) due within 7 days		
Materials	●	1 late order(s) · 1 delivery after install date · 2 order(s) due within 7 days		
Decisions	●	2 decision(s) past decide-by date · 0 due within 7 days		
Issues	●	1 open high-severity · 5 open in total		

In your download

- **..._DEMO.xlsx** — a realistic example renovation, frozen on 15 Jun 2026 so every feature shows something. Open this first to explore.
- **..._BLANK.xlsx** — the same workbook, empty and ready for *your* project.
- This guide.

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1 · Open the file in Microsoft Excel

Get started

- 1 Save the **BLANK** file somewhere safe, e.g. a “Renovation” folder on your computer or OneDrive.
- 2 Open it in **Microsoft Excel**. If Excel shows a yellow “Protected View” bar, click **Enable Editing**.
- 3 Start on the **Start Here** tab.

Requirements

- Microsoft Excel 2016, 2019, 2021, 2024 or Microsoft 365.
- Windows or Mac.
- No macros, add-ons or internet connection needed.
- A computer is recommended — the tabs are designed for a full screen.

Renovation OS is built and supported for Microsoft Excel only. Other spreadsheet apps (such as Google Sheets or Apple Numbers) do not support all of its features and protection.

Tip: keep an untouched copy of the BLANK file as a backup, and save your project file regularly (Excel ► File ► Save). If you store it in OneDrive, Excel keeps version history for you.

2 · The only rule: yellow = you type

-  **Light-yellow cells** are yours: type, or pick from the ▼ dropdown.
-  **White / grey cells** calculate automatically. They are locked, so nothing can break.
-   On track — nothing to do.
-   Needs attention soon (within your alert window).
-   Urgent — overdue, over budget or at risk.

3 · Set up in 10 minutes

- 1 **Start Here.** Project name, start date, target move-in date and total budget (including tax). Choose your **currency, tax name, m² or ft², and the day your week starts**. A safety buffer (contingency, 10% by default) is set aside automatically — what is left is your *working budget*.
- 2 **Budget.** Give each category a budget. Rename, add or clear categories freely. Try to make the total match your working budget — the check at the top tells you.
- 3 **Contractors.** One row per company: contract value, signed yes/no, start and end dates. Update “% work complete” every week — it powers the “paying ahead of work” warning.

- 4 **Payments.** Enter each payment milestone (a % of the contract or a fixed amount) with its due date. Add invoice and paid dates as they happen.
- 5 **Timeline.** The typical task list is pre-filled. Set durations (days) and the **Predecessor ID** — the task that must finish first. Dates, the Gantt chart and your forecast move-in date follow automatically.

What is a “Predecessor ID”? Every task has a number. If task 11 “Rough-in inspection” can only start after task 8 “Plumbing rough-in”, type **8** in task 11’s Predecessor column. When plumbing slips, the inspection — and everything after it — moves too. The predecessor must be a task listed *above* (a lower ID).

4 · Your weekly routine (10 minutes)

Monday — plan

Open the **Dashboard**. Work through “**Your next actions**” from top to bottom: overdue payments, late tasks, decisions and follow-ups are already ranked by urgency.

PRO **This Week** shows everything due this week plus a Friday review.

During the week — update

Record payments and invoices, mark tasks Done, log problems on **Issues**, and update each contractor’s % work complete. Everything else recalculates.

YOUR NEXT ACTIONS — ranked by urgency

33 ACTIONS NEED YOUR ATTENTION					
#	Priority	What to do	Where	Due	When
1	Urgent	Decision overdue: Living room flooring	Selections & Orders	23 May 2026	23 days overdue
2	Urgent	Late task: Plumbing rough-in — FlowRight Plumbing	Timeline	05 Jun 2026	10 days overdue
3	Urgent	Should have started: Heat pump & ventilation — ClimaHeat HVAC	Timeline	06 Jun 2026	9 days overdue
4	Urgent	Overdue payment: FlowRight Plumbing — Rough-in complete 40% (€ 3,680)	Payments	10 Jun 2026	5 days overdue
5	Urgent	Follow up with Bright Spark Electric: Asked for revised schedule after 1-week slip — no reply yet	Contractors	10 Jun 2026	5 days overdue
6	Urgent	Issue action due: Socket positions don't match kitchen plan → Send marked-up plan to electrician	Issues & Punch List	11 Jun 2026	4 days overdue
7	Urgent	Decide on change order CO-5: EV charger + 6 extra circuits (+€ 3,400)	Change Orders	12 Jun 2026	3 days overdue
8	Urgent	High-severity issue: Rotten joist found under living room floor → Engineer to confirm repair method	Issues & Punch List	12 Jun 2026	3 days overdue
9	Urgent	Order late — install at risk: Sink & tap	Selections & Orders	13 Jun 2026	2 days overdue
10	Urgent	Decision overdue: Bathroom 2 tiles	Selections & Orders	14 Jun 2026	1 day overdue

+ 23 more — see This Week and in each tab.

5 · Every tab in one line

Tab	What it does
Start Here	Your project settings, preferences and this routine.
Dashboard	KPIs,    health score, ranked next actions, charts.
Budget	Budget vs committed vs invoiced vs paid, forecast final cost and risk.
Contractors	Contracts, insurance/licence checks, paying-ahead warning; communication log on the right → .
Payments	Payment schedule and invoices; per-contractor summary and 12-month cash flow on the right → .
Timeline	Tasks, dependencies, delays, late warnings and a 52-week Gantt chart.
Issues & Punch List	Problems on site and end-of-job snags, with owner, cost and deadline.
This Week PRO	Monday plan and Friday review.
Quotes PRO	Up to 4 quotes side by side; the hidden-cost checklist gives the TRUE cost and a 🏆 winner.
Change Orders PRO	Preview a change's effect on budget, contingency and move-in date before approving.
Rooms PRO	One card per room: money, progress, decisions, issues.
Selections & Orders PRO	Choices (tiles, taps...) with automatic decide-by and order-by dates.
Vault PRO	Links to contracts, invoices, photos + ✓ checklist of missing documents.
Warranty & Maintenance PRO	Warranty expiry dates and recurring home maintenance, with reminders.

Lite users: there is no Change Orders tab — add approved extras to the contractor's contract value. There is no Selections tab — enter big material suppliers (worktop, appliances...) as contractors.

6 · Good to know

“The cell won’t let me type.”

It is a calculated (white) cell — it is locked on purpose. Type only in yellow cells.

How many rows can I use?

Every list has 1,000 ready rows (Budget: 50 categories). Just use the next empty yellow row — please don't insert or delete rows.

The demo shows dates in 2026 and never changes.

The demo is frozen on 15 Jun 2026 via Start Here ► “Today” override, so every feature shows data. Clear that cell to see it live. Your BLANK file always uses today's date.

Why is a budget line red?

Its forecast is above its budget. While a category is still *Estimating* the forecast uses the highest of budget, best quote, committed and invoiced — deliberately pessimistic until you sign.

Amounts show no € or \$ sign.

By design: the symbol is in every column header and follows your Currency choice on Start Here. Thousand separators follow your computer's regional settings.

Can I use it on several projects?

Yes — for your own home(s), keep a fresh copy of the BLANK file for each project.

Tip that pays for this file: never let the % you have paid a contractor run far ahead of the % of work done, and hold back the last payment until the punch list is finished.

Need help?

If something is unclear or you think you found a problem, send me a message through the shop where you bought it (Etsy or Gumroad). Please include which tab and cell you are looking at — a screenshot helps.

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